



“I have called on twilight,
midnight, and dawn, because
a sorceress has bewitched me.”

MAQLU TABLET 1, c.1600 BCE

doubled as doctors, and another tablet contains a spell calling on Gula, the goddess of health, to drive out the ghost making a patient ill.

Baru engaged in extispicy (divination by examining the entrails of sheep). They also observed celestial signs, such as eclipses, haloes around the sun (which portended the destruction of a city), irregularities in the movements of Venus, and cloud conditions. More unusual portents included the birth of deformed animals or conjoined twins, and even a red dog urinating on a man—a predictor of happiness.

▼ Incantation bowl

A very late example of the Mesopotamian magical tradition, this bowl, from the 5–7th centuries CE, contains an incantation in Aramaic and depicts a demon in the center. Such bowls were often buried at the corners of rooms for protection.

temple priests, in particular *ashipu* (exorcists), who performed magical rituals, and *baru*, who interpreted omens. Palace archives were stocked with collections of clay cuneiform tablets containing spells, incantations, and omens. Huge numbers have been recovered from the palace library of the Assyrian king Ashurbanipal. Ordinary people also called on the services of *ashipu* to cast protective spells, and used amulets and enchanted figurines to dispel evil spirits.

Anti-witchcraft and omens

Personal misfortune or sickness was often blamed on witches or demons. Witches were also thought to secretly put curses on people. Priests developed rituals to counteract malign influences and collected them in nine Maqlu tablets, first compiled around 1600 BCE. They were passed down through generations of *ashipu* for about the next thousand years. A collection of 100 incantations, across eight of the tablets, enabled the *ashipu* to identify and tame evil magic; the last tablet gives instructions for a ritual to banish a curse, which involved burning a figurine of the witch responsible. Exorcists often

